

FIJI: A LOVE STORY (Memoirs of an Unconventional Diplomat)
By Ajay Singh
SHIPRA PUBLICATIONS
₹550; 176 pages

his enduring admiration for his wife, Shiromani, about which he writes with great feeling. It is this bond that saw the author through many ups and downs till she was snatched away by cancer. Not long afterwards, Ajay passed away, leaving an unpublished and not quite finished manuscript on Fiji. Fortunately, with the help of his friends and colleagues, it has come out as both a fine historical chronicle and a personal saga. ■

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'disillusioned idealist' and renewed commitments in politically engaged publishing and with a collective of agricultural labourers in Ibrahimpatnam—is recounted with sentiment but without sentimentality. The passage describing her sojourn as an 'Underground' member of the Andhra Pradesh Revolutionary Communist Party during the Emergency years is brief but remarkably clear-eyed. Yet this is not merely a political narrative but a story of the passions and compassions of a full and considered life. ■

UPHOLDER OF THE GOOD BOOK

By Amitabha Pande

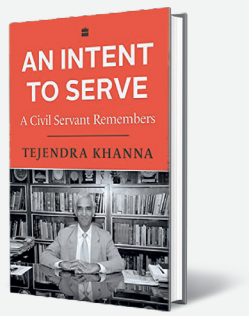
An IAS officer of the Punjab cadre who served as chief secretary of Punjab during very turbulent years, Tejendra Khanna retired as India's commerce secretary in 1996 and served twice as Delhi's Lieutenant Governor. By all accounts, his career was not just successful in terms of many personal achievements, it was free of controversy and marked by composure and grace.

Khanna's autobiographical account, *An Intent To Serve: A Civil Servant Remembers,* traces his growth from the time of his entry into the IAS in 1961 till he demitted office in 2013. It is in the nature of a self-portrait through many vignettes from different stages of his career. While we do get a fleeting glimpse into some of the major political events of his time, his focus is more on telling a personal story of what went into the making of an honest, upright and straight-thinking civil servant.

It is difficult to say precisely what it was that distinguished officers of that generation from those in service now, but Khanna's book highlights some stark differences. First, the general educational background of entrants into the service, when the emphasis was on a broad-based education either in the liberal arts and humanities or in the sciences. More value was attached to breadth of knowledge than to specialisation in specific 'domains'. A person with a master's degree in physics, for example, would take care to be well-informed in literature, or history and vice versa.

It was this all-round ability that is evident through Khanna's extraordinarily diverse and multifaceted career. It is a reminder that the ability to integrate inputs from a diversity of domains is far more important for administrative leadership than specialisation in a single domain.

Moreover, the challenge



AN INTENT TO SERVE
A Civil Servant Remembers
By Tejendra Khanna
HARPERCOLLINS
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then offered by a career in public service—the 'intent to serve'—genuinely mattered more than the prospects of power and privilege. Idealism was not considered naive. To be fair, impartial and give equal respect to everyone was a creed, a 'dharma' fundamental to one's career. Added to this was a consciousness of the fact that as a member of the only constitutionally covenanted public service in the world, an officer owed primary loyalty to the Constitution and not to the political executive of the day. This 'privilege' was a vital part of an officer's self-identity and gave him/her the strength to stand up to and resist powerful vested interests.

Khanna repeatedly stresses this 'esprit de corps' to show how it enabled him to navigate some extremely turbulent waters throughout his career without ever deviating from the norms of constitutional conduct.

It is remarkable that despite his tenacity of purpose, he deftly avoided controversy and conflict. Of particular interest are his two stints as Delhi's L-G when, as the executive head of the government, he managed to hold his own without getting into conflict with two very differen but politically important chief ministers, Sahib Singh Verma and Sheila Dixit, both of whom had major differences of opinion with him.

Lastly, it was the value attached to command over languages and the ability to express oneself with clarity, precision and forcefulness. It is easy to see in Khanna's book a quality he shares with others of his generation: of being able to express himself in simple, unadorned, yet elegant prose. It is a pity that many of these characteristics are now a rarity. The 'intent to serve' has been replaced by the intent to wield power and access privilege, constitutional conduct is subject to political expediency, language skills are poorer and 'esprit de corps' is a forgotten value. Khanna's book is a reminder of what we have lost, for that reason alone it deserves to be read. ■

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